DAY 1 -Thursday, November 13th 2025

Location: **St Edmund's College, Okinaga Room**

10:00-10:30	*Coffee, tea, and pastries served upon arrival, at 10:00* **OPENING REMARKS**
10:30-12:00	**SESSION 1** **The Trouble with Integration: Bridging and Contesting Knowledge Practices during Health Emergencies** (Luisa Enria, London School of Hygiene & Tropical Medicine) *Coffee, tea, and biscuits served at 11:00*
12:00-13:00	**LUNCH BREAK** *At St. Edmund's Cafeteria* *Lunch served at 12:30*
13:00-14:30	**SESSION 2** **Hermeneutical Friction: Philosophical Theorization and Empirical Fieldwork on the Ground** (Ying Huang, Independent Researcher) *Coffee, tea, and biscuits served at 14:15*
14:30-16:00	**SESSION 3** **Chineseness here and there: rethinking the social construction of races through objective kinds** (Edwin Jiang, Independent Researcher.)

*Presenters' dinner will take place at **19:00** in **The Architect**, near the College.*

DAY 2 -Friday, November 14th 2025

Location: **St Edmund's College, Okinaga Room**

10:00-10:30	*Coffee, tea, and pastries served upon arrival*
10:30-12:00	**SESSION 4** **Kinds of kinds and the anthropology of art** (Javier Ruiz del Río, University of Cambridge) Response from: Timothy Carroll (UCL) *Coffee, tea, and biscuits served at 11:00*
12:00-13:00	**LUNCH BREAK** *At St. Edmund's Cafeteria* *Lunch served at 12:30*
13:00-14:30	**SESSION 5** **Epistemic Hypochondriacs: Claiming a We in Anthropology** (Anna Bloom-Christen, University of St. Gallen.) Response from: Yazan Doughan (LSE) *Coffee, tea, and biscuits served 14:15*
14:30-15:30	**DISCUSSION** **(Closed session)** ☐ **Steps forward -** Network plans, activities, publications
15:30-16:00	**CONCLUDING REMARKS**

PAPER ABSTRACTS:

1. The Trouble with Integration: Bridging and Contesting Knowledge Practices during Health Emergencies (*Luisa Enria*)

The 2014-16 West African Ebola outbreak brought together new constellations of people, ways of knowing and evidence making practices that did not otherwise often interact. As the crisis unfolded, anthropologists, clinicians, civil society activists and healers, had to find ways to collaborate, including how to confront difference and contestations over the authority of evidence. In the aftermath of Ebola, this has generated novel experiments in 'integrating' different ways of knowing during emergencies. This field offers a window into contemporary questions in anthropology and beyond for how we understand, represent and engage with epistemological and ontological divergence. In this sense, the article contributes to contemporary discussions at the interface between anthropology and philosophy on the ontological turn, and particularly on notions of alterity, proposing how empirical insights derived from ethnographic research can help illuminate how these questions are negotiated practice in people's daily lives. Drawing on long-term fieldwork in Sierra Leone and in global policy and practice fora, this article offers an empirical account of integrative experiments, tracing discourses, everyday encounters and imaginations. Through two examples—anthropologists' struggles to integrate ethnographic evidence in epidemic response and healers' fraught role in crisis landscapes—I illustrate how integration has remained primarily 'absorptive', assimilating 'other' knowledge into dominant biomedical paradigms. At the same time, taking seriously existing aspirations for working together and confronting the political economy of knowledge that underpins integration, also reveals immanent potentialities for doing collaboration otherwise.

3. Epistemic hypochondriacs: Claiming a We in Anthropology (*Anna Bloom-Christen*)

Anthropologists rely on shared actions to access the lifeworlds of others, producing claims about the minds and intentions of those they study. Yet this process is fraught with epistemic anxiety. Clifford Geertz famously described anthropologists as "epistemic hypochondriacs", perpetually concerned about the validity of their interpretations and the risk of faulty approximations when attempting to translate lived experiences into scholarly representations. This worry is not merely epistemological but also deeply ethical. Engaging closely with research participants and representing their lives in academic and public forums entails a responsibility to portray them with dignity and in their full complexity. The concern, therefore, is not only about getting it right but about ensuring that these representations are both justified and just.

The primary empirical method in anthropology, participant observation, fundamentally depends on the transfer of knowledge through shared action and joint attention. Through these interactive processes, anthropologists gain insights into the practices and meanings of those they study, generating the foundations for ethnographic writing. Ethnographies, in turn, are constructed as textual mediations of these shared experiences, embedding the dynamics of joint attention into their narrative and analytical structures.

This paper examines the evolving role of shared action in anthropological practice and its broader implications for understanding social ontology. By tracing key moments in anthropology's history, I show how debates about shared action and joint attention have shaped

the discipline's methodologies and theoretical frameworks. I argue that these debates mirror and contribute to ongoing discussions in social ontology concerning the conditions and dynamics of shared agency.

To bridge the gap between current debates in anthropology and philosophy, I draw on Åsa Burman's notion of nonideal social ontology, which prioritizes the messy, situated realities of human interaction over idealized models. This perspective illuminates how anthropologists navigate the complexities of shared action in asymmetrical or contested contexts, offering insights into the dynamics of shared action under nonideal conditions.

By bringing nonideal social ontology into conversation with anthropological practice, this paper highlights how both fields can inform and enrich each other's approaches. Anthropology's attention to the complexities of knowledge production through shared action and joint attention can deepen philosophical discussions of power inequalities, while nonideal social ontology offers a framework for understanding these interactions in asymmetrical contexts.

4. Chineseness here and there: rethinking the social construction of races through objective kinds (*Edwin Jiang*)

This paper re-examines the identity of the Chinese people (zhonghua minzu) within the ethnographic settings of 21st century moral education within a public school in the People's

Republic of China (PRC) and amongst Chinese international students abroad. Engaging with literatures from the anthropology of nationalisms and ethnicities (e.g., Holmes 2000; Smedley 1998), while also drawing upon recent interrogations of race and identity in analytic philosophy (e.g., Haslanger 2012), this paper argues the nationalistic tropes fundamental to contemporary Chinese identity, such as the "century of humiliation" (*bainian guochi*) or "crises of extinction" (*miezu weiji*) are sustained in the imaginations of my interlocutors based on a perceived subordination of racialized groups outside of China. More specifically, this paper demonstrates how the perceived subordination of Han Chinese abroad is used to perpetuate Han privilege at home within the PRC, whether in terms of Han supremacy, Han paternalism, and racism. Theoretically, the paper demonstrates one way ethnicity and race can and do constitute an objective type without relying on mythological notions of blood and soil. Consequently, the paper illustrates how dominant social scientific attempts at debunking Chinese nationalist identity fail to recognize the reality of the ways minority identities are racialized tout court through a neglect of social ontology. Although the paper is sympathetic to the political aims of these social constructivist debunking projects, it proceeds to critique the invocation of Chinese identity in contemporary PRC moral education not through an insistence on the unreality of such an identity, but rather by pointing out the internal contradictions of nationalistic discourses about this identity encountered through fieldwork.

5. Kinds of kinds and the anthropology of art (*Javier Ruiz del Rio*)

This paper proposes a picture of social ontology as the meeting ground between philosophy and anthropology through the example of Western art. Whether art should be taken as a kind of thing or another is not a complete choice; however, neither is it given to us directly by empirical

investigation. Building on my own ethnographic work among Western artists, I demonstrate the relevance of pragmatic research concerns and theoretical commitments for social explanations of artistic phenomena. The paper is divided into the following way. First, I will describe a vignette in which I talk to students in an art school to highlight the equivocal nature of "art" in Western contexts. Second, I examine the reasons to conceive it as a "natural" kind, suggesting it might be conducive to various anthropological aims. I will focus on two influential examples from anthropological theory (Boas and Gell) and their causal explanation. Third, I consider the alternative (art as an "artifactual" kind), which appears more amenable to contemporary "property cluster" theories and anthropological relativism. Viewing art in this way, however, is far from solving the difficulties for the dialogue between anthropology and philosophy. On the contrary, it opens up a multiplicity of new questions for the researcher, including how our categories hark back to the world, or whether artifactuality is merely a matter of conventionality. Fourth, I return to a specific problem suggested by my ethnography. Even if I, as an anthropologist, took art for an artifactual kind, my interlocutors employed it as a natural one. Taking inspiration from the cognitive anthropology of religion, I suggest analysing it as what Pascal Boyer called a "pseudo-natural" kind. Finally, I conclude with some remarks on what the anthropology of art can tell us about this dialogue with philosophy, focusing specifically on the challenge to foundationalist social ontologies it creates.